

His Third LEASE OF LIFE

India's best and the brightest came together for the 12-hour surgery on the prime minister

With 8,000 patient footfalls a day, the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) has learnt not to give in to hysterical medical dramas. And even as last week's special guest, Dr Manmohan Singh, went under the scalpel and the most-talked about surgery of recent times became the favourite televisual discourse of the nation, it triumphantly resisted. The VIP operation theatre on the third floor was out of bounds for anyone without identity proof. Phone calls from the media had no effect. A medic cracked a joke, "You can go in there only if you are Gursharan Kaur, Upinder, Daman or Amrit."

Yet as citizens debated the suddenness of the 76-year-old prime minister's operation, the pros and cons of a beating heart surgery or the duration, inside news trickled out: The prime minister had said, "I am ready" while being wheeled to the OR; that after the 12-hour surgery, Dr Ramakanta Panda, the lead surgeon, had famously declared, "We don't look at the clock"; or how Dr K.S. Reddy, former head of cardiology at AIIMS and Manmohan's personal physician, had dismissed the charge that AIIMS was being "bypassed" by the Asian Heart Institute of Mumbai with, "This is team India batting for the prime minister."

But there are still many questions doing the rounds: How quickly can he recover? Will he emerge healthier or not? "Even some years ago, medics were told we were pushing the envelope to operate on a 70-something," says Dr Ashok Seth, chief cardiologist of Max Devki Devi Heart & Vascular Institute in Delhi. "Today we're operating on 90-year-olds." The first 48 to 72 hours hold the clue to the prime minister's recovery, medics hold. There is expectation and a degree of nervousness in the air. But the nation will remember this moment more as a coming together of the Delhi Daredevils and Mumbai Indians as Manmohan starts on the road to recovery.

by Damayanti Datta



Went through a cataract operation in the right eye in 2008

He had a triple-vessel coronary artery disease, with a bypass and stenting done earlier. Despite the blockages, his heart's pumping action has remained intact.

Had surgeries on his wrists to relieve pressure on a nerve in 2008

Had a surgery for benign enlargement of the prostate gland last year

The PM is diabetic. He doesn't have chronic lung or kidney diseases.

He has a disciplined lifestyle, is a non-smoker and does yoga and meditation regularly

Overall health status: "In good shape"

Matters of THE HEART



SHEILA DIKSHIT, 70
Chief Minister, Delhi
Despite a second bypass in 2001, it is business as usual for Delhi's longest serving chief minister. She went on to win two more elections after that.



ARJUN SINGH, 78
Union Minister for Human Resource Development
A diabetic, he suffers from serious cardio-artery disorder and his medical history includes a bypass surgery

